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Final Critical Essay

Did Ye Hear Mammy Died?

Séamas O'Reilly's *Did Ye Hear Mammy Died?* is a witty, tender, and thoughtful memoir, set primarily in Derry, Northern Ireland in the 1990s, during a period of sectarian conflict known as the Troubles (Wallenfeldt). In this piece, O'Reilly reflects on the early loss of his mother, as readers are taken through stories of his childhood—being raised among ten siblings in a single-father household. Since its release on June 9, 2020, this memoir has amassed notable acclaim from publications such as *National Public Radio* and *Erie Reader*, as well as highly positive scores from user reviews on *Goodreads* (Martin; Kutz; “Did Ye Hear Mammy Died? A Memoir”). The following essay aims to identify the memoir’s intended purpose, and to analyze the author’s elements of craft and technique used to achieve its goals—pulling from articles, interviews, and examples from the work itself.

Intended Purpose and Goals

As explained by Mura, a writer's core intent is to paint a fully-realized portrait of a given social unit (e.g., a person, a family, society, etc.), by discussing its hidden and unmentioned facets (17). In other words, writers must explore “the erasures no one talks about” (17). Considering that O'Reilly initially knew little about his late mother—a result of losing her at an early age (O'Reilly 40)—the memoir's intentions hold two main goals: To present a realized

portrait of Mammy by unearthing these erasures, and to reflect on the author's own grief in the process. In essence, the memoir aims to posit O'Reilly as "an ambassador" for his mother's legacy (Roy, *The Irish News*). Passages within the memoir itself appear to discuss potential driving forces behind the author's intentions: "I was so young when Mammy died that I sometimes felt as though I didn't know her well enough to grieve the same way my older siblings did, and that it was somehow false for me to claim the same pain as them" (O'Reilly 206). Given this information, we can now discuss how the author uses craft and technique to achieve the memoir's intent.

Research Methodologies

In terms of literary craft, it is important to note O'Reilly's research methodologies, and their role in achieving the memoir's intent. To paint a multi-faceted portrait of his mother, the author primarily gathered information by interviewing family members, and his mother's old friends. O'Reilly expands on this in his interview with *The Irish News*: "I was constantly asking them questions about things that I just couldn't know, or was too young to have picked up on or just plain forgotten. And my mum's friend Patricia definitely had all the stories about her, good and bad" (Roy, *The Irish News*). Patricia in particular proved to be a bountiful resource for O'Reilly, as the memoir notes how she provided him with old letters written by his mother (100). O'Reilly discusses the contextual impact of these letters within the memoir: "They cover my mother's near-constant visits to people in hospitals, or attendance at funerals, and the care she gave to Daddy's mother in the final stages of her life, eschewing the hospice in favor of letting her see out her days in the company of her grandchildren. They document her own illness too, and the changing fortunes of her battle with cancer. But mostly they give encouragement, support

and offers of prayerful solidarity to Patricia, alongside exhaustive updates on what we were all up to” (100). While this excerpt is lengthy, it sheds light on the amount of contextual information that the author derived from this resource. Through this, O’Reilly’s research methodologies prove themselves to be crucial toward the memoir’s craft, and achieving the author’s intentions.

Structure

In terms of technique, O’Reilly plays with various forms of structure to both convey an image of his mother, as well as to reflect on his own process of grief. This can be seen within the memoir’s third chapter, *Mother’s Day*, in which the author discusses the remaining memories he has of her, and reflects on the fear of forgetting her entirely (O’Reilly 38-53). The memories are conveyed to the reader as a list—a string of vignettes. They appear in the form of short personal anecdotes (each with their own sub-header) and are ordered by number from one to eight. Structuring his memories from one to eight re-emphasizes to the reader how little he knew about his mother, allowing readers to sympathize with his grief. Additionally, many of the author’s listed memories read like candid snapshots of his mother, offering readers a more intimate understanding of who Mammy really was. This is observable within the chapter’s sub-headings, such as “3. She is coming in to pick me up from school,” or “5. She is dancing with Daddy” (41-43). Finally, it is important to note that while the author engages with memory in this structure, they also acknowledge how memories can prove unreliable (45). O’Reilly expands on this, stating: “Even light reading on the subject suggests that memories are scarcely trustworthy things, so I don’t really know how many of these are fully real recollections drawn from focusing on aspects of my life that were too painful to consider for the past three decades, or half-fudged fakes contrived from going over other people’s stories and looking at old photographs” (45).

Through this acknowledgement, the reader is rest assured that the author is attempting to preserve a true image of his subject, by means of addressing his own potential biases.

Voice - Tone, Description, and Confession

The most notable applications of both craft and technique come through the author's use of voice. As noted in a book review by the *National Public Radio*, O'Reilly's dark and humorous approach to the topic of grief and his mother's death had readers laughing frequently (Martin). Additionally, this unique approach resonated with readers who have experienced similar losses to O'Reilly, as emphasized in the review: "I laughed out loud reading *Did Ye Hear Mammy Died*, especially at the bits that recalled for me the way my own family laughs to keep from crying" (Martin). Thus, this section of the essay explores how the author utilizes voice to achieve the memoir's intentions.

Consider the following line from the memoir's first chapter, in which O'Reilly reflects on understanding his mother's death, from the perspective of his childhood self: "Months later, in much the same manner of a man who remembers a packet of Rolos in his coat pocket, I'd straighten my back with delight and perkily ask the nearest larger person when Mammy was coming back, on account of how she'd been dead for ages and was, surely by now, overdue a return" (19). Here, O'Reilly unpacks a grim subject, but uses a comedic image or symbol (e.g., the Rolos) to make the topic more approachable to readers. Another example can be found in the third chapter, in which O'Reilly reflects on how others in his community would approach him, following his mother's passing: "They'd ask about my dad a lot, and say how wonderful we all were, and him especially, but in a tone that suggested it was simply miraculous we hadn't beaten ourselves to death with lead pipes from all the grief" (48). Here, O'Reilly addresses the struggle

of interacting with others during the earlier stages of his family's grief, and conveys this notion through the means of dark (yet effortlessly charming) imagery. Additionally, this tone of voice can be found in both the memoir's chapter titles (e.g., Chapter Six: *An Entire Chapter About Dogs and Priests*) and even the title of the memoir itself: *Did Ye Hear Mammy Died?* (80). In essence, these examples serve to fulfill the memoir's intentions, through a tone that proves both humorous and digestible to the reader.

While O'Reilly attempts to preserve this voice throughout the memoir, there are many notable instances where the author adopts a profoundly poetic and descriptive tone: "I couldn't help picturing Mammy – lovely, tired and blue-tinged in her flowy white hospital gown – awakening to a frenzy of mechanical beeping as the roof caved in and tubes burst from the machines" (9). Here, the author instills an image that captures multiple facets of Mammy's character, such as her warm-hearted nature, evidenced by the use of "lovely" (9). We can also derive a ghostly essence of beauty from this line, evoked through colorful descriptors such as "blue-tinged" and "flowy white hospital gown" (9). Then, towards the end of the passage, we are given a dark, grim, and eerie image of her struggle with death, evidenced through the malfunctioning hospital equipment surrounding her. This contrasting image depicts the facets of Mammy's character that one would rather not think about, but through its inclusion, the author presents an image that is equal parts haunting, beautiful, and realistic in its description. In essence, O'Reilly's voice will adopt a poetic tone to authentically describe Mammy's image to the reader, thus fulfilling the memoir's intentions.

Finally, O'Reilly's voice is used to confess his own grief, in an attempt to build trust with the reader through vulnerability. This is observed in the following passage, in which the author confesses the grief of holding little-to-no memory of Mammy, and considers how this plays a

role in his identity: “I sometimes wonder if my impulse to read everything, know everything and broadcast to everyone all of these wonderful everthings I knew, well into my teens, was all about beating the encroaching darkness of things forgotten, about proving that I would and could never let my guard down again. The boy who knew everything couldn’t possibly have forgotten his own mother” (40). Through this vulnerable confession, O’Reilly not only achieves the memoir’s goal of reflecting on his grief, but gains the reader's trust, by addressing the fact that his memory of Mammy is limited. Thus, the reader is ensured that all depictions of Mammy moving forward will preserve the essence of truth. As a result, readers are able to feel a sense of acceptance and authorial trust in O’Reilly’s words. It highlights the importance of authorial confession, as discussed by Febos: “If I brought my burdens, my unspoken and perhaps unspeakable thoughts and deeds, maybe I could exchange them for the mercy of acceptance” (Febos). Put simply, O’Reilly’s use of confession helps the memoir achieve its intentions.

Conclusion

In the final analysis of *Did Ye Hear Mammy Died*, two key intentions of the memoir were identified: To present a realistic, multi-faceted depiction of Mammy’s image, and to reflect on the author’s process of grief. These goals were effectively achieved using various elements of craft and technique, including the author’s use of research, structure, and voice. Ultimately, *Did Ye Hear Mammy Died?* remains a grimly-hilarious and authentically-poetic memoir.

Word Count: 1,776

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